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Marketing analytics capability, artificial intelligence adoption, and firms' competitive advantage: Evidence from the manufacturing industry

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ABSTRACT

Data-driven analytics and artificial intelligence (AI) have become the most crucial aspects of today's industrial marketing management. Although many firms have embraced analytics and AI strategies, corresponding academic advances have been slow. This research investigates how industrial goods manufacturers sustain their competitive advantage in export markets, convincing buyers in a competitive data-rich business environment. The evidence has been taken from the RMG (readymade garment) industry, one of the largest manufacturing industries significantly attached to the export markets. Utilizing multi-phase research design, the study reveals that firms marketing analytics capability play a vital role in sensing, seizing, and reconfiguring the market, consequently leading to a sustained competitive advantage. The performance of sensing, seizing, and reconfiguring becomes higher for a firm when they adopt AI on the strength of the marketing analytics platform. These findings exhibit the latest avenue of exploration within marketing analytics and AI's academic research paradigm. Further, in practice, managers will be aware of the facts that create resilience in this specific industry context.

1. Introduction

"Prior to the COVID-19 pandemic's stranglehold on the world, leaders increasingly embraced advanced analytics and artificial intelligence (AI) for a good reason. These capabilities are expected to offer annual economic value between $9.5 trillion and $15.4 trillion. Organizations are standing up analytics capabilities in a matter of weeks to inform business responses to COVID-19 challenges and prepare for the future"… McKinsey&Company *(2020)*.

A business without data is now unimaginable. Data acts as 'the oil' for the digital economy since businesses generate meaningful insights from enormous data streams utilizing the power of marketing analytics (Wedel & Kannan, 2016). Notably, scholars from the marketing domain frequently highlight the appropriate use of analytics for tackling the disruption in marketing science and practice (Moorman, 2016; Urban, Timoshenko, Dhillon, & Hauser, 2020). Overall, marketers can use marketing analytics to decide how to use their marketing resources efficiently for business operations, find and keep customers or buyers who are likely to be profitable, and balance demand and supply coordination (Rahman, Hossain, & Fattah, 2021). Marketing analytics is vital in shaping businesses to reach a new height. Researchers have also significantly contributed to providing directions in the academic literature on how marketing analytics impacts firms to drive their businesses and achieve long-term advantages in a B2C context (Addo, Akpatsa, Nukpe, Ohemeng, & Kulbo, 2022; Song, Zheng, Zhang, & Yu, 2018). However, research on marketing analytics capability is limited in the pure B2B manufacturing firm context.

Evidence suggests that manufacturing industries are fairly involved in exporting goods (Moktadir, Rahman, Rahman, Ali, & Paul, 2018). Readymade garment (RMG) has been categorized as one such

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